

CRIME

10Investigates: Knoxville license plate reader cameras turned off after contract lapse

Attorneys warn that the loss of data could hinder investigations for months. KPD says it's switching to a new vendor with cameras expected to go up later this year.

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KNOXVILLE, Tenn — License plate reader cameras used by the Knoxville Police Department have been switched off following a contract lapse, and it'll be months before new ones become operational.

Knoxville attorneys say the technology has proved crucial in criminal and other investigations, both to help police and to help clear defendants suspected of crimes.

The city's previous vendor, Flock, shut off the cameras Jan. 1 after its contract expired. Knoxville police say the department is transitioning to a new vendor, Axon, but new cameras

may not be installed and operational until the middle of the year.

License plate reader cameras collect vehicle data that can be used to place people at crime scenes, track suspects and investigate crashes or hit and runs.

"Flock cameras basically record license plates and other data, and so they're very important," said T. Scott Jones, a Knoxville attorney. "According to published reports they solve approximately 15% of all crimes across the United States."

Jones said law enforcement relies on them "day in, day out." The cameras have proved to be among the most effective new technological tools for crime and traffic enforcement, he said.

Jones said the loss of the cameras impacts far more than criminal cases.

"When they're active, these cameras are utilized to place people at the scene, and it's not just criminal activity," Jones said. "Perhaps it's accidents and it's other sets of circumstances where it's important to record that data, and without the data, obviously that's a real problem."

Knoxville police confirmed they attempted to secure a short-term contract extension with Flock before the agreement expired, but no deal was reached. The department's contract with Flock expired Dec. 31, 2025. Flock turned KPD cameras off Jan. 1 without notifying the department, a KPD spokesman said.

The department said Axon cameras will better integrate with existing police systems once installed.

Until then, Jones said investigations could suffer. He said the absence of license plate reader data is especially challenging in certain types of cases.

"In hit-and-run type cases, things of that nature... you are relying upon law enforcement to have this data available and then it's not available," Jones said. "It becomes a hardship and so we're having to pursue alternative means to figure things out. It's kind of like we've abandoned the computer and we've had to pull the typewriter back out."

License plate readers are just one form of technology used for enforcement across the city. Knoxville has also used noise-monitoring cameras and approved traffic cameras in school zones.

KPD told 10News Wednesday the first school zone speed cameras should be installed within the next 4-8 weeks. There will be "public communications surrounding that and before any citations or warnings are issued," KPD said.

The city has been planning for months to install two noise cameras downtown – but their installation is not imminent, according to the city.

